

The “Yes And”: How to Say No Without Saying No

When you're at capacity and a partner arrives with a new assignment, a flat “no” feels risky. So the yes slips out, and you pay for it later. The Yes And protects your capacity without a no ever leaving your mouth.

1 Say yes first.

“I’d love to help with this.”

2 Ask about the deadline.

“Is that a hard deadline, or is it movable?”

3 Show your plate.

“Here’s what else I’m working on right now.”

4 Hand back the prioritization.

“How would you prioritize these?”

Example

“I would love to do this for you. Is that a firm deadline? Is it movable? Here’s what else I’m managing. How would you prioritize it?”

If your capacity truly doesn’t work: keep a referral in your pocket.

“I know [associate] could do a great job with this if the timing doesn’t work on my end.”